



**PIRATES ARE SEAFARERS** who take goods, ships, or people with violence, and then usually share their spoils within a male-led collective. Since piracy relies on seafaring and combat—traditionally skills that women were excluded from—female pirates have been rare. In the past, there was great resistance to women being allowed on ships at all as they were seen as unlucky and a distraction for male crews. Although occasionally a few women were accepted on the seas as the captain’s wife or widow, many female buccaneers cross-dressed as men to gain admittance to a pirate crew.

Historically, the term “pirate” when used in relation to women often described a tough female associated with any bloody, sea-related adventures. For example, Artemisia (see right), the 5th-century BCE

“**No warlike chief or Viking ... had bolder heart than she.**”

SONG OF GRACE O’MALLEY, 1798

#### ◀ Pillaging the high seas

A 1961 movie poster for *Mary La Rousse, Femme Pirate* (*Queen of the Seas*) about the cross-dressing English pirate, Mary (Mark) Read, who was convicted of piracy in the early 18th century.

THROUGH THE AGES

# Piracy

There have been few female pirates, but those that have lived as ruthless, sometimes cross-dressing, buccaneers are surrounded by myths. Popularly regarded as liberated, transgressive heroines, today they are more likely to be based in an office.